Philemon 1–7 — Leader / Learner Guide

A Cautious Approach · a one-page guide for leaders and learners

The Epistle to Philemon · TheGospelVault.com · @iJohn.316 (Instagram)

① Big Idea and Context

> **Big idea:** Paul, who had all the leverage he could want, approaches Philemon cautiously — claiming him, wishing him grace and peace, thanking God for him, and rejoicing over him — to set the stage with great Christian tact for the appeal to come.

Onesimus, a thieving, runaway slave, met Paul in Rome and through Paul met the Lord. Now he is going back to his master Philemon in Colossae with Tychicus and this letter.

- **The situation:** a runaway slave, now a believer, returning to an owner who could punish or even kill him.
- **The approach:** the velvet glove, not the iron fist — greetings, grace and peace, gratitude, gladness.
- **The goal:** that Philemon receive Onesimus "not as a slave, but as a brother in Christ."

② The Velvet Glove — Three Anchor Verses

Verse	What it says	Teaching point
v. 1	*"Paul, a prisoner of Christ Jesus, … to Philemon our beloved friend and fellow laborer"*	Paul claims Philemon as "our" own. There is nothing like expressed appreciation of fellow workers.
v. 5	*"hearing of your love and faith … toward all the saints"*	Love grows out of faith — and "all the saints" now includes Onesimus. One of Paul's digs.
v. 7	*"the hearts of the saints have been refreshed by you, brother"*	σπλάγχνα — the innermost being; "refreshed" is Jesus' word in Matt. 11:28. "Brother" sets the stage.

Grace: not only unmerited favor but favor in spite of demerit (Rom. 5:8).
Peace: believers have peace with God (Rom. 5:1); Paul wishes them the peace of God (Phil. 4:6–7).

③ Teaching Flow

1. **Introduction.** Who Onesimus was, why he feared going back, and the questions about slavery the letter raises.
2. **Greetings (vv. 1–2).** Paul's condition and companion; how he claims and commends Philemon, Apphia, and Archippus.
3. **Grace and Peace (v. 3).** The Father; the Lord (power), Jesus (person), Christ (position); peace with God vs. the peace of God.
4. **Gratitude (vv. 4–6).** When, why, and what Paul prayed — love for all the saints, faith in the Lord, effective sharing.
5. **Gladness (v. 7).** Joy and consolation; hearts refreshed "by you, brother" — the stage set for vv. 8–19.

④ Clarify While Teaching

- **"Tychicus," not "Ticacus":** the recording is unclear; Tychicus carried Colossians (Col. 4:7–9).
- **"The sister" (v. 2):** the sermon's point follows the critical text ("the sister"); the NKJV reads "the beloved Apphia."
- **Peter walked on water — not as proof of deity:** the sermon's point is that works prove Messiahship (Matt. 11:2–6); the title "Lord" carries His deity.

⑤ Discussion and Close

1. Who in your life needs to hear you say, "You are a blessing to me" this week?
2. What burden have you taken to the Lord in prayer and then picked back up again?
3. Where is the "dig" in v. 5, and how does it prepare for Paul's request?

Close: Point ahead to vv. 8–19, "A Comprehensive Appeal": Paul could command, but for love's sake he appeals. "The great Christian tact. We need it."

Full study: A Cautious Approach — Philemon 1–7 · Source: The Gospel Vault